Love & absence

Thoughts seek presence

1 Sonnet 29: the idea

Barrett Browning's thoughts resemble vines growing around the beloved tree. They express desire but can hide the real person.

The speaker wants actual presence. Commands make her an active voice in love.

2 Sonnet 29: the method

A **Petrarchan sonnet:** 14 lines. Early turn with Yet starts rejecting thought as a substitute. Ending reverses the opening.

Natural growth becomes release as greenery falls. Context: Sonnets from the Portuguese and love for Robert Browning.

Waiting deepens distress

3 Dusting the Phone: the idea

Kay's speaker fears disaster whether the telephone rings or stays silent. Every outcome feeds uncertainty.

Polishing and dressing for the personified phone suggest service to an object that controls the day.

4 Dusting: the method

Free verse and tercets lead to an isolated last line. Fragments and questions interrupt attempts at control.

Modern domestic communication makes dependence concrete. The lover's gender is not specified; the speaker is not automatically the poet.

Compare the resolution

5 A shared problem

Sonnet 29 → Imagined release

Dusting the Phone → Unresolved wait

Absence makes imagination powerful. Browning uses a growing plant; Kay uses a household device.

Both speakers address a beloved and want more than imagined contact. Compare how desire is voiced.

6 A different ending

Browning imagines closeness freeing her from thought. Kay's attempted ultimatum collapses into uncertainty.

Build an argument about **control,** then connect metaphor, changing tone and ending. Do not give two separate summaries.